

CMS / DAM Feature Ranking Workshop

Session Date: June 24, 2026 · Purpose: Vendor Evaluation Feature Prioritization

Executive Summary

B&H; is evaluating approximately 10 CMS platforms and a DAM solution. This workshop gathered cross-functional stakeholder input to rank features as Must Have, Nice to Have, or Not Needed — directly informing vendor shortlisting. The team is aligned on a **headless, API-first CMS** direction with heavy weight on structured content modeling, editorial workflow, and governance. A key strategic question surfaced: **whether a DAM is needed at CMS launch (Phase 1) or should be deferred to Phase 2.**

CMS Features

■ MUST HAVE

Feature	Key Discussion Notes
Visual / WYSIWYG Editing	4+ stakeholders cited as top priority. Clarified: not out-of-the-box — developers build templates/components first; editors then work within those guardrails.
Structured Content Modeling	Highest architectural priority. Discrete typed fields (title, subtitle, CTA) vs. a single free-form HTML dump. Foundation for all other features.
Reusable Components / Content	Must-have for campaign consistency. Distinction: reusable components (structural) vs. reusable content (same copy across multiple banners).
Page-Creation Flexibility	Ability to create one-off landing pages, editorial pages, and category pages within the developer-established framework. Includes modular layout within guardrails.
Multi-Step Editorial Workflow	Required for content governance — writer → reviewer → publisher roles. Key use cases: blog publishing, product overview copy, legal review path.
Role-Based Access with SSO	Unanimous yes. Directly tied to multi-step editorial workflow requirements.
Granular Content & User Activity Audit Logging	Strong yes. Must track who changed what and when — ideally a full per-item edit history. Exportability noted as desirable.
Webhooks & Event-Driven Workflow Automation	Must-have for integration. Use case: trigger Jira ticket or email on publish event. Current Drupal setup lacks this capability.
Scheduled Publishing & Embargo Management	Unanimous yes. Critical for campaign launches — content staged but not public until a specified go-live time.
Headless / API-First Architecture	De facto requirement given tech direction. 'API-first' treated as a buzzword — actual requirement is robust REST or GraphQL APIs.
Performance at Scale	Must-have. CMS publishes to edge servers; performance varies by vendor based on GraphQL vs. REST and caching implementation.
Version History, Content Rollback & Audit Trail	Must-have. Full history of every edit required — not just 'last edit' as some CMSs provide.
Full Staging Environment with Preview	Must-have with clarification: in-CMS preview = nice to have; full staging environment (e.g., staging.bhphotovideo.com) = the actual requirement.
Personalization / Rules Engine (Geo & Segment)	Must-have for geo-targeted banners (e.g., Florida-only). CMS needs a rules engine evaluating API call parameters (IP, user data) to return the correct content variant.
Metadata & Taxonomy-Driven Tagging	Must-have for content structure and discoverability. Applies to both CMS content and DAM assets.
Total Cost of Ownership	Critical evaluation factor. Pricing models vary widely. Strategy: shortlist by features first, then use TCO as tiebreaker. Lock pricing via contract.

Feature	Key Discussion Notes
Product / Platform Maturity	<i>Added during session. Reference to past pain with immature vendors (e.g., Ceros). Vendor stability is a must-have criterion.</i>

■ NICE TO HAVE

Feature	Key Discussion Notes
A/B and Multivariate Testing Capability	<i>Long discussion. Conclusion: A/B testing does not have to live inside the CMS, but the CMS must be compatible with server-side testing (e.g., AP Tasty via cookie/feature flag). CMS must serve two content variants when queried. Question mark noted — moved to bottom of nice-to-have.</i>
Personalization Based on Browsing Behavior	<i>Nice to have once native AI or CDP infrastructure is in place. Not done manually at scale today.</i>
Native AI with Ability to Connect to 3rd-Party Systems	<i>Early stages. Noted as a growing differentiator among CMS vendors.</i>
Native AI to Assist with Content Operations	<i>Nice to have. Clarified: AI-assisted (SEO auditing, consistency flagging, edit suggestions) — NOT AI-generated content. Spell check / content quality enforcement example given.</i>
Native Analytics / Deep 3rd-Party Analytics Integration	<i>Nice to have. For real-time personalization, a CDP may be the better architectural choice. CMS-native analytics better suited to reporting than live behavioral decisions.</i>
Developer-Friendly Ramp-Up Time	<i>Nice to have. More complex CMSs may take 5 months to implement vs. 3 months for simpler ones. Certification time also a factor.</i>
Multi-Site Management	<i>Nice to have — flagged as 'Gratis' use case (future sister brand sites, regional sites). Not a current B&H; need.</i>
Brand Portal for Controlled External Asset Sharing	<i>Currently handled via shared links. Would be an upgrade.</i>
Ability to Create / Edit Form Data	<i>Developer-built forms editable by content authors = already covered under structured content. Net-new form creation by non-devs = nice to have.</i>
Image Hotspot / Interactive Banner Support	<i>Raised late in session. Primarily a custom development task. Example: click a banner region to surface a tooltip or product link.</i>
Responsive Banner Image Cropping via CDN	<i>Nice to have. CDN can handle crop/resize via pixel parameters. Product images already handled separately. Some CMSs support focal point / crop region specs; many do not.</i>

■ NOT NEEDED

Feature	Key Discussion Notes
Content Localization & Multi-Language Support	<i>No current need. Spanish / Portuguese site was discontinued.</i>
SaaS Maintained	<i>Not a requirement either way. On-prem vs. SaaS treated as a neutral consideration.</i>
Native Video Support & Management	<i>Currently using third-party hosting. Not needed in CMS. (Note: late disclosure that some teaser videos may now be app-hosted — facilitator flagged as new info.)</i>
Omni-Channel Delivery	<i>Discarded. All headless CMSs inherently support multi-channel via API — not a differentiating feature.</i>

DAM Features

Open Strategic Question: Do we need a DAM at CMS launch? A CMS-native media library can handle some DAM functionality but breaks down at scale. A full DAM is likely needed long-term due to an ongoing branding/asset-sharing initiative. Tentative group consensus: **DAM is Phase 2 unless a vendor bundles both at compelling cost/feature parity.**

■ MUST HAVE

Feature	Key Discussion Notes
Metadata & Taxonomy-Driven Tagging	<i>Critical for image naming conventions, searchability, and consistency at scale.</i>
AI-Assisted Auto-Tagging & Asset Categorization	<i>Strong yes. Reduces manual effort and fat-fingering on large asset uploads. Especially valuable for initial migration of legacy assets.</i>
Workflow-Driven Asset Approval & Review (Multi-Team Routing)	<i>Yes — maps to how the Imaging team currently works. Applies to video and music assets as well.</i>
Role-Based Access Control with Granular User Permissions	<i>Yes. Required for brand governance and controlled sharing.</i>
Advanced Search & Filtering by Asset Attributes, Tags & Metadata	<i>Yes. Core DAM utility.</i>
Version Control & Full Asset Change History	<i>Yes. Current Imaging system has some history; DAM needs to formalize and extend this.</i>
Automated Image Transformation & Multi-Resolution Rendition Generation	<i>Must-have specifically for banner imagery (not product images, already handled). Want responsive rendering from a single upload with CMS/CDN controlling crop/size parameters.</i>

■ NICE TO HAVE

Feature	Key Discussion Notes
Brand Portal for Controlled External Asset Sharing	<i>Currently done via shared links. Upgrade worth having if bundled.</i>
Digital Rights Management & Usage Rights Tracking	<i>Nice to have — relevant if B&H; expands lifestyle imagery / stock photo library (initiative mentioned as in progress).</i>
Native Analytics / Deep 3rd-Party Analytics Integration	<i>Nice to have for DAM-level reporting.</i>
Native AI with Ability to Connect to 3rd-Party Systems	<i>Nice to have — differentiator among more advanced DAM vendors.</i>
Native AI to Assist with Content Operations	<i>Nice to have — AI-assisted tagging suggestions, quality checks, consistency enforcement.</i>

■ NOT NEEDED

Feature	Key Discussion Notes
Native Video Support & Management	<i>Not needed. Currently third-party hosted; no plan to change.</i>

Open Discussion Threads — Action Required

1. A/B Testing Architecture

Context: B&H; uses server-side testing with cookies. The CMS must host two content variants and serve the correct one based on a feature flag parameter. It does not need a built-in testing UI.

Next Step: Dev team to confirm exact technical requirement. Include as a mandatory vendor RFP question.

2. Personalization Rules Engine (Geo / Segment)

Context: CMS needs a rules engine OR the application layer sends user data (state, segment, IP) with every API call and CMS returns the correct content variant.

Next Step: Dev team to clarify preferred approach: CMS-native rules engine vs. application-layer logic. Include in RFP.

3. WYSIWYG Expectations

Context: Some stakeholders expected out-of-the-box drag-and-drop editing. In a headless CMS, WYSIWYG requires developers to build templates first — editors work within those guardrails, not a blank canvas.

Next Step: Share clarification broadly with content and marketing teams before vendor demos.

4. Responsive Banner Image Handling

Context: CDN can handle crop/resize if given pixel parameters. Some CMSs support this natively; many do not. Product images already handled separately.

Next Step: Add to RFP: 'Does your CMS support CDN-native responsive image parameters or focal point / crop region specs per breakpoint?'

5. Workflow Management UI / UX

Context: No card was created for CMS internal interface quality (dashboards, task assignment, content queues). Stakeholder noted this matters significantly across writer, designer, and dev teams.

Next Step: Add UX/UI quality of workflow management as a demo evaluation criterion when shortlist is ready.

6. DAM Phase Decision

Context: Tentative agreement that DAM is Phase 2, but a larger asset-sharing initiative may accelerate timing.

Next Step: Confirm with leadership: is DAM in or out of scope for Phase 1 RFP? If out, preserve DAM must-haves for a future RFP.

7. Multi-Site Management Growth Path

Context: Not a current requirement but a viable growth scenario (sister brands, regional sites). 'Gratis' company cited as context.

Next Step: Ensure chosen platform supports multi-site as a growth path, even if not activated at launch.

Recommended Next Steps

#	Action
1	Distribute finalized feature ranking to all session participants for review and sign-off.

2	Build a vendor evaluation scorecard using Must Have features as pass/fail criteria and Nice to Have features as weighted scoring factors.
3	Draft RFP / vendor questionnaire incorporating technical clarifications from open threads (A/B testing, rules engine, responsive images, multi-site).
4	Schedule vendor demos for shortlisted CMS platforms — demo script must include: workflow management UI, WYSIWYG walkthrough for a content author, and structured content modeling demonstration.
5	Confirm DAM phasing with leadership — include or defer from Phase 1 scope.
6	Align content and marketing teams on WYSIWYG expectations before demos to prevent misaligned expectations.
7	Share A/B testing architecture discussion with dev team to confirm technical requirements before vendor conversations begin.

Notes compiled from session transcript and whiteboard photography — June 24, 2026 · B&H; Photo Video — CMS / DAM Evaluation